



BOOTLEGGERS PAY PROTECTION MONEY TO POLITICIANS AND THE POLICE TO KEEP THE BUSINESS RUNNING

“ There is no question of changing the law. On the contrary, we will strictly implement it.”



AMIT SHAH, HOME MINISTER

“ Prohibition breeds corruption and is a money loser. It should be scrapped.”



CHIMANBHAI MEHTA, JANATA DAL LEADER

Wet 'n' WILD

Many states tried prohibition but had to backtrack later

The Bansi Lal government kept its election promise and introduced prohibition in Haryana in 1996. But bordered by three states, implementing the policy became difficult, giving rise to liquor mafias. Besides, the state was losing

about Rs 1,100 crore a year. The policy was repealed after only 21 months.

The N.T. Rama Rao-led TDP government declared Andhra Pradesh dry in 1995 with a clear eye on the women's vote but prohibition was repealed

by his son-in-law N. Chandrababu Naidu who seized power following a family coup in 1997.

Tamil Nadu, dry until 1971, went wet only to revert to prohibition in 1974. Repealed dry laws in 1981 and wet since.

Others differ, the state's hotel industry for one. Says Darius Merchant, general manager of the Gateway Hotel Ummed at Ahmedabad, a Taj Group five-star hotel: "There's a very strong case in Gujarat for partially relaxing the prohibition policy. Allowing beer and wine will give a major boost to tourism in the state." Around 30 lakh tourists, including one lakh foreigners, visited Gujarat in 2008. This figure, according to the state Tourism Department sources, would have been around 40 per cent more, had there been no prohibition. Says former Union minister and Janata Dal leader Chimanbhai Mehta, himself a teetotaler: "Prohibition law has lost all its meaning and is only a major source of corruption and revenue loss to the state." He is brave enough to go on record demanding scrapping of prohibition

while most of the city's elite, many of them known to have a glass or two of the amber stuff after sundown, are coy about talking of total scrapping of prohibition. Says a senior retired police official: "In a large number of cases the police officials themselves create bootleggers by asking underworld dons to start illicit liquor distilleries to earn easy money. The annual illicit liquor business in Gujarat is said to be in the region of about Rs 1,500 crore and in many places, local politicians are partners with the police." This nexus between the police and bootleggers has only encouraged the gangsters. Also, postings for policemen in places like Surat, Valsad and those near the Rajasthan border, the entry points for smuggled liquor, are the most sought after.

Tipplers have never had it so good in the country as now. There are more

varieties of wine, beer and hard liquor for consumers to choose from. India is also one of the fastest growing alcohol markets in the world and consumed more than 350 million cases of IMFL and over 225 million cases of country liquor in the last year, spending nearly Rs 12,000 crore in the process. By Modi's own admission, the state loses out on over Rs 3,000 crore in excise revenue every year. More than 150 years ago, the American President Abraham Lincoln said: "Prohibition goes beyond the bounds of reason in that it attempts to control man's appetite through legislation and makes a crime of things that are not even crimes. Prohibition strikes at the very principles upon which our government was founded." It is a statement that holds true for the world's oldest as well as its largest democracy. ■